

The Sūtra on Cultivating Loving-Kindness

Maitrī Bhāvanā Sūtra · Toh 36 · Derge Kangyur

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The Sūtra on Cultivating Loving-Kindness, known in Sanskrit as the Maitrī Bhāvanā Sūtra and in Tibetan as Byams pa bsgom pa'i mdo, is a canonical Buddhist discourse in which the Buddha, while residing at Śrāvastī in the Jeta Grove, instructs his monks on the practice of loving-kindness as a method for liberating the mind. The text belongs to the sūtra literature and centers on the enumeration of eleven benefits that arise from cultivating loving-kindness diligently, presenting it as a foundational meditative quality to be steadied, developed, and thoroughly familiarized. It is Toh 36 in the Kangyur, where it is classified among the general sūtras of the collection.

Translated, edited, and finalized. May it be like the sun and moon upon the earth.

In the language of India: Maitrī Bhāvanā Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra on Cultivating Loving-Kindness. With reverence I bow to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada.

Then the Blessed One called the monks together. When the venerable monks had each come before the Blessed One, he spoke these words:

"Monks, you should cultivate loving-kindness in order to liberate the mind. You should do so in order to make your intention steady: practicing it much, calming it, making it a foundation, dwelling in it, growing familiar with it, and striving in it with great diligence. The eleven benefits should be explained one by one. What are those eleven? Sleeping happily, waking happily, not seeing evil dreams, being loved by people, being loved by non-human beings, being protected by the gods, not being harmed by fire, poison, or weapons, the mind dwelling always in great joy, the complexion becoming brilliantly clear, dying with a clear mind, and — through having cultivated great mindfulness — being born in the Brahmā world.

Monks, you should know not to be separated from the mind of loving-kindness. Make your intention steady. Cultivate it, practice it much, calm it, make it a foundation, dwell in it, grow familiar with it, and strive in it with great

diligence. The benefits of the eleven have now been explained one by one.

Monks, the further benefits of loving-kindness should also be explained.

One obtains abundant food
and lives at ease in one's own land.

Many beings find their livelihood
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

In whatever villages and towns one travels,
in royal cities and palaces,
everywhere one will be honored —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

No thieves will arise against that one,
no king will do that one harm,
and all sentient beings will become friends —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

Free of anger, dwelling at ease in one's own land,
beloved without blame in the place of one's birth,
one comes to have the finest companions —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

When one makes offerings, offerings are received in return;
when one bows, obeisance is returned in kind;
fame and renown are attained —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

When one shows honor, honor is obtained;
when one shows respect, respect is received;
one comes to possess a radiant and majestic complexion —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

One will become like the body of a god,
blazing and resplendent as fire,
and never be separated from glory —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

One obtains many cattle,
grain grows abundantly in the fields,
and sons and daughters become many —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

When one falls headlong from a mountain,
when one tumbles down from a tree,
one does not come to harm but finds a safe place to land —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness.

When one has climbed to the top of a vaṭa tree,
just as the wind cannot move it,
so enemies cannot do even the slightest harm —
through one who has not abandoned loving-kindness."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the monks rejoiced in what the Blessed One had taught.

The Sūtra on Cultivating Loving-Kindness is complete.

From the presence of the great paṇḍita Ānandaśrī, the translator of vast learning, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo, rendered this translation and edited it at the great assembly place of those who speak both languages, the glorious great temple of Tharpa Ling, and finalized it. May it be like the sun and moon upon the earth.

Translator's Notes

- The vaṭa tree mentioned in the penultimate verse is the Indian banyan tree, famous for its extraordinary stability and size; the simile turns on the tree's near-immovability in the wind. The name is left in its Sanskrit form as it appears in the Tibetan transliteration.

The colophon identifies the translator as the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo, working from the presence of the great paṇḍita Ānandaśrī, at the temple called Tharpa Ling. The opening line — "May it be like the sun and moon upon the earth" — appears both at the very beginning of the passage as transmitted and again at the colophon; it is a standard auspicious formula framing the text.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of

stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.